

Dear Willow Springs Community Association Board of Directors,

I am writing in strong support of the proposed pedestrian and bicycle bridge connecting Willow Springs to the Mail Creek Trail. I live on Pacific Court with my family, including two young children, and I have a background in federal policy analysis. I am also an avid cyclist who rides over 100 miles per week on Fort Collins' trail network. I offer this letter not merely as someone with a personal stake in the outcome, but as someone trained to evaluate policy proposals on their merits. This proposal is, by any reasonable measure, an extraordinary opportunity for our community.

I have reviewed both the informational flyer distributed by community members in support of the bridge and the opposition flyer that appeared on our doors. I have also spent considerable time researching the relevant data on property values, crime, trail usage, and the broader policy context. What follows is a thorough analysis of why this bridge deserves our community's enthusiastic support.

I. What Is Actually Being Offered

Let us begin with the basic facts, because the debate surrounding this issue has introduced enough ambiguity to obscure what is actually a remarkably straightforward proposition.

The City of Fort Collins is offering to build, at no cost to Willow Springs homeowners, an ADA-compliant pedestrian and bicycle bridge connecting our neighborhood to the newly completed Mail Creek Trail. Construction would be funded through Colorado's lottery-funded conservation programs, most likely the Colorado Conservation Trust Fund, which receives a portion of its funding through Great Outdoors Colorado (GOCO), a program created by Colorado voters in 1992 through a constitutional amendment dedicating lottery proceeds to conservation and recreation projects.¹ GOCO has invested in over 5,900 projects across all 64 Colorado counties.² This is not general tax revenue, and it is not discretionary spending—it is money constitutionally earmarked for exactly this type of project. If Willow Springs declines, these funds will simply be allocated to another community. We would not be “saving” money; we would be giving it away.

The timing is critical. The Siphon Pedestrian Overpass opened on December 5, 2025, completing a \$4.7 million infrastructure project that, for the first time, provides a safe crossing over the Union Pacific Railroad tracks between Harmony and Trilby roads.³ This overpass connects the Mail Creek Trail to the Power Trail, which is one of Fort Collins' most important north-south trail arteries. The Mail Creek Trail itself, which opened in 2024, passes behind Bacon Elementary and through the

¹ Great Outdoors Colorado (GOCO), "2025 Strategic Plan." GOCO was created by Colorado voters in 1992 through Amendment 8, a constitutional amendment dedicating a portion of Colorado Lottery proceeds to parks, trails, wildlife, and open space. Bridge funding is expected to come through the Colorado Conservation Trust Fund, which receives a portion of its funding via GOCO. <https://goco.org/about/>

² GOCO, "Funded Projects." As of 2025, GOCO has helped fund over 5,900 projects in all 64 Colorado counties. <https://goco.org/about/funded-projects>

³ City of Fort Collins, "Siphon Pedestrian Overpass." The overpass opened December 5, 2025, connecting the Mail Creek Trail to the Power Trail over Union Pacific Railroad tracks. <https://www.fortcollins.gov/Projects/Siphon-Pedestrian-Overpass>

City's new Tailwinds Park.⁴ Our proposed bridge would connect us directly to this brand-new infrastructure and existing important community amenities. This is the final link in a chain that the City has spent years and millions of dollars building, and it leads directly to the heart of Fort Collins' Platinum-rated trail network.

II. The Data on Property Values Is Overwhelming

The single most extensively studied question in trail policy is whether proximity to trails increases or decreases property values, and the evidence is unambiguous.

A comprehensive review by Crompton and Nicholls published in the *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration* examined 20 studies using hedonic pricing analysis, which represents the gold standard methodology for isolating the effect of specific amenities on home prices. They found that trail-adjacent homes command a premium of 3–5%, with outliers as high as 15%.⁵ Another study of the Little Miami Scenic Trail in Ohio found that each additional foot of distance from the trail decreased sale price by \$7.05.⁶ The National Association of Realtors (NAR) reports that buyers often pay more to live in walkable communities with nearby parks and recreational amenities, and identifies proximity to multi-use trails as a top requested amenity.⁷ Opinion surveys further support these data: across 2,647 households residing near 24 urban trails, only 6% perceived a negative impact on property values, while 47% perceived an increase.⁸

Applying these findings to our community, the median home sale price in Willow Springs was approximately \$630,000 from January 2023 to January 2026.⁹ A conservative 3% premium translates to \$18,900 per home. A 5% premium would be \$31,500. Across the 460 properties in our neighborhood, we are talking about an aggregate property value increase between \$8,694,000 and

⁴ City of Fort Collins, "Siphon Pedestrian Overpass" The Mail Creek Trail, which opened in 2024, connects the intersection of Zephyr and Tilden to the Siphon Overpass site, passing behind Bacon Elementary and through the new Tailwinds Park. <https://www.fortcollins.gov/Projects/Siphon-Pedestrian-Overpass>

⁵ Crompton, J.L. and Nicholls, S., "The Impact of Greenways and Trails on Proximate Property Values: An Updated Review," *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration* (2019). Review of 20 hedonic pricing studies finding a 3–5% property value premium for trail-adjacent homes. <https://talbotthrive.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/Impact-Greenways-and-Trails-on-Property-Values.pdf>

⁶ Karadeniz, D., "The Impact of the Little Miami Scenic Trail on Single Family Residential Property Values," Master's Thesis, University of Cincinnati (2008). Statistical hedonic analysis finding sale price decreased \$7.05 for each additional foot of distance from the trail. https://www.como.gov/wp-content/uploads/2021/02/trail_eco_impact_study.pdf

⁷ National Association of Realtors, "Survey: Buyers May Pay More to Live in Walkable Communities," *Real Estate News* (reporting on NAR survey data finding that buyers often pay more to live in communities with nearby parks, recreational amenities, and multi-use trails, and that trail proximity is among the top requested amenities influencing purchase decisions). <https://www.nar.realtor/magazine/real-estate-news/survey-buyers-may-pay-more-to-live-in-walkable-communities>

⁸ Crompton, J.L. and Nicholls, S., "The Impact of Greenways and Trails on Proximate Property Values: An Updated Review," *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration* (2019). Reviewing opinion survey data from 2,647 households across 24 urban trails, only 6% perceived negative property impact and 47% perceived increase. <https://talbotthrive.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/Impact-Greenways-and-Trails-on-Property-Values.pdf>

⁹ Redfin, "Willow Springs Housing Market." Neighborhood market data for Willow Springs, Fort Collins, CO; median sale price approximately \$630,000 for homes sold January 2023 through January 2026. <https://www.redfin.com/neighborhood/121882/CO/Fort-Collins/Willow-Springs/housing-market>

\$14,490,000. Compare that to whatever marginal increase in HOA dues maintenance would entail, and the math is not close.

III. The Crime Argument Does Not Survive Contact with Data

The anonymous opposition flyer raises crime as a primary concern, claiming that Poudre Fire Authority and Fort Collins Police reports show “crime and trail history” but that the committee “refuses to share it so homeowners won’t be scared.” This is an unfalsifiable assertion that is based on data that the claimant does not have access to. That alone should give any thoughtful resident pause.

This issue has been extensively studied, and national data on trail-related crime is clear.

The Conservation Fund, in partnership with Colorado State Parks, studied three Denver trails in detail and found that “no public safety issues could be directly linked to the trail.”¹⁰ Another survey of 15 cities found only minor infractions related to trail proximity, primarily illegal motorized use, littering, and unleashed pets.¹¹ A study of the Brush Creek Trail in Santa Rosa, California, concluded that trail existence did not cause an increase in crime, and if anything, had a positive effect on the quality of life in the neighborhood.¹² The Indiana Trails Study, the most comprehensive U.S. study of its kind, reached the same conclusion across six trail projects.¹³ Study after study reaches the same finding: the fear of trail-related crime is a pre-construction anxiety that does not materialize post-construction.

In terms of what we know about crime in our community specifically, third-party neighborhood crime mapping sites (e.g., CrimeGrade) suggest that southeast Fort Collins has lower modeled violent-crime risk than most other parts of the city. For example, CrimeGrade estimates a 1-in-263 annual risk of violent-crime victimization in the southeast versus 1-in-113 in the north.¹⁴ While those tools use modeling based on official statistics to provide more granular geographic insights,

¹⁰ The Conservation Fund and Colorado State Parks, State Trails Program, “The Effect of Greenways on Property Values and Public Safety” (1995). Study of three Denver-area trails found no public safety issues directly linked to the trails. Summarized in American Trails, “Trail Effects on Neighborhoods: Home Value, Safety, Quality of Life.” <https://www.americantrails.org/resources/trail-effects-on-neighborhoods-home-value-safety-quality-of-life>

¹¹ Murphy, M., “The Impact of the Brush Creek Trail on Property Values and Crime,” Sonoma State University (1992). A survey of 15 cities found that reported trail-related problems were limited to minor infractions such as illegal motorized use, littering, and unleashed pets. Summarized in American Trails, “Trail Effects on Neighborhoods: Home Value, Safety, Quality of Life.” <https://www.americantrails.org/resources/trail-effects-on-neighborhoods-home-value-safety-quality-of-life>

¹² Murphy, M., “The Impact of the Brush Creek Trail on Property Values and Crime,” Sonoma State University (1992). Concludes the Brush Creek Trail did not cause an increase in crime. Summarized in American Trails, “Trail Effects on Neighborhoods: Home Value, Safety, Quality of Life.” <https://www.americantrails.org/resources/trail-effects-on-neighborhoods-home-value-safety-quality-of-life>

¹³ Wolter, S. and Lindsey, G., “Summary Report Indiana Trails Study: A Study of Trails in 6 Indiana Cities,” Eppley Institute for Parks & Public Lands, Indiana University (2001). The most comprehensive U.S. rail-trail study examined six trail projects across Indiana and found that trail neighbors consistently reported no measurable increase in crime. https://www.brucefreemanrailtrail.org/pdf/Indiana_Trails_2001.pdf

¹⁴ CrimeGrade.org, “Fort Collins, CO Violent Crime Rates and Maps” (2025 data). Third-party crime-risk modeling tool estimating neighborhood-level violent crime risk. Southeast Fort Collins modeled at 1-in-263 annual risk versus 1-in-113 in northern areas. <https://crimegrade.org/violent-crime-fort-collins-co/>

similar conclusions can be drawn from official statistics: Fort Collins Police Services publishes official, reported crime information for the community.¹⁵ Fort Collins Police Services reports 475 violent FBI index crimes in 2024 — roughly 2.8 per 1,000 residents — which is well below the national rate of approximately 3.6 per 1,000.¹⁶ In terms of how Fort Collins residents actually experience safety, the City's Community Survey provides a more complete picture: roughly 9 in 10 residents rated overall safety positively, and 8–9 in 10 said they usually or always feel safe on trails and in their neighborhood at night.¹⁷ The bottom line is that we live in a safe community, within one of its safest areas, and our fellow community members perceive our trails as overwhelmingly safe.

Aside from statistics, I would like to offer a personal observation. I ride my bike through this area virtually every day, year-round, at whatever time of day works with my schedule. I know this trail network intimately. The notion that a pedestrian bridge over Mail Creek Ditch is going to serve as a conduit for criminal activity in one of the safest corners of a city with low rates of crime is, to be direct, not a serious argument. It is a feeling masquerading as a fact.

IV. The “Timberline Connection” Is Not a Substitute

The opposition's fallback position is that Willow Springs already has adequate trail access via the Timberline Road connection. This argument reveals a fundamental misunderstanding of how people, especially children and families, actually use active transportation infrastructure.

Timberline Road is a four-lane, 40 mph arterial street. The “connection” requires riding along a sidewalk adjacent to high-speed traffic, traveling south to reach the Mail Creek Trail, and then traversing a considerably longer route to access the Siphon Overpass and Power Trail. For an experienced adult cyclist, this adds unnecessary and unpleasant riding. I do it because I have no choice, but it is neither enjoyable nor efficient.

For a child, the calculus is entirely different. And this is the point the opposition consistently fails to engage with.

Transportation planners have a concept called the “last mile problem,” which is the recognition that even excellent infrastructure fails if people cannot safely and conveniently access it. The Mail Creek Trail is outstanding. The Siphon Overpass is a feat of engineering. But for a 9-year-old on a bicycle living in Willow Springs, none of that matters if the only way to reach it requires navigating

¹⁵ Fort Collins Police Services, "Crime Stats and Prevention" (official City of Fort Collins crime reporting and neighborhood crime mapping portal). 2024 data: 475 violent and 3,777 property FBI index crimes reported.

<https://www.fortcollins.gov/Services/Police-and-Public-Safety/Police-Services/Crime-Stats-and-Prevention>

¹⁶ Federal Bureau of Investigation, "UCR Summary of Reported Crimes in the Nation, 2024." The FBI estimated 359.1 violent crimes per 100,000 population nationally in 2024 (approximately 3.6 per 1,000 residents).

<https://cde.ucr.cjis.gov/LATEST/resources/reports/UCR%20Summary%20of%20Reported%20Crimes%20in%20the%20Nation%202024.pdf>

¹⁷ City of Fort Collins, "2024 Community Survey: Report of Results" Professionally administered citywide survey of resident perceptions of safety and quality of life; approximately 9 in 10 residents rated overall safety positively; 8–9 in 10 reported feeling safe on trails and in their neighborhood at night.

<https://www.fcgov.com/communitysurvey/files/fort-collins-2024-community-survey-report-of-results-fin.pdf>

alongside a four-lane road where drivers routinely exceed the speed limit. That half-mile Timberline detour is not a minor inconvenience, it is a barrier that determines whether a child can ride to school, to a friend's house, or to Tailwinds Park independently. It is the difference between a family choosing to bike somewhere on a Saturday morning and deciding it's just easier to drive.

My older daughter attends school in this area. Right now, the idea of her riding her bike to school via Timberline is something I simply would not allow, not because she isn't capable, but because the route requires riding alongside traffic where a single moment of inattention, hers or a driver's, could be catastrophic. With the proposed bridge, she could ride on a dedicated, off-street trail the entire way. That is not a marginal improvement. That is a transformational one.

Research supports this distinction. An evaluation of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's Safe Routes to School programs found that infrastructure improvements increased active school travel from 12.9% to 17.6%, with walking alone increasing from 9.8% to 14.2%.¹⁸ Studies in Denmark found that children who bike to school have lower BMI and better cardiovascular fitness.¹⁹ A Spanish study of 1,700 adolescent girls showed that those who walked or biked to school performed better on standardized cognitive assessments.²⁰ The bridge would not just be convenient, it would contribute to our children's physical and cognitive development.

V. The Costs Are Negligible; the Opportunity Cost Is Enormous

The opposition flyer asserts that the project "is not FREE" and that homeowners will face special assessments and increased HOA fees. This issue is nuanced and deserves elaboration.

First, the capital cost of the bridge and trail installation is, in fact, free to homeowners. Conservation grants fund the construction. The opposition's concern is about ongoing maintenance in terms of the cost of maintaining a short spur trail connecting to the bridge. This is primarily snow removal and occasional surface maintenance on what amounts to a few hundred feet of 10-foot-wide concrete path.

To put this in perspective, Willow Springs already maintains miles of internal pedestrian paths, a clubhouse, a pool, common area landscaping, a pond, and playground equipment. The incremental cost of maintaining a short trail spur is, in the context of our existing maintenance obligations, negligible. It is the kind of expense that might add single-digit dollars to an individual

¹⁸ Stewart, O., Moudon, A.V., and Claybrooke, C., "Multistate Evaluation of Safe Routes to School Programs," *American Journal of Health Promotion*, 28(3 Suppl):S89–S96 (2014). Evaluation of 48 SRTS projects across 53 schools in Florida, Mississippi, Washington, and Wisconsin found active school travel increased from 12.9% to 17.6%, with walking increasing from 9.8% to 14.2%. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/24380471/>

¹⁹ Ostergaard, L. et al., "Cycling to school is associated with lower BMI and lower odds of being overweight or obese in a large population-based study of Danish adolescents," *Journal of Physical Activity and Health*, 9(5):617–625 (2012). <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/22733866/>

²⁰ Martínez-Gómez, D. et al., "Active commuting to school and cognitive performance in adolescents: the AVENA study," *Archives of Pediatrics & Adolescent Medicine*, 165(4):300–305 (2011). Study of approximately 1,700 adolescent girls in five Spanish cities finding improved cognitive assessment scores among active commuters. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/21135316/>

homeowner's annual HOA dues. Meanwhile, research suggests each individual home would gain tens of thousands of dollars in home equity.

But the truly significant cost is the one the opposition never mentions: the opportunity cost of saying no. The City is offering us a GOCO-funded bridge right now. GOCO's Community Impact grants range from \$100,000 to \$2,000,000 and are highly competitive.²¹ If we decline this offer, there is no guarantee it will be extended again. We would be permanently forgoing a multi-hundred-thousand-dollar infrastructure investment in our neighborhood because we are worried about snow removal on a short stretch of concrete. That is not prudent fiscal management.

VI. The Opposition's Arguments Contradict Each Other

I want to draw attention to several logical inconsistencies in the opposition's position, because they are instructive.

Contradiction #1: Access is already adequate, but outsiders will flood our common areas. The opposition simultaneously argues that 1) Willow Springs already has perfectly adequate trail access via Timberline, and 2) building the bridge would cause outsiders to use our common areas as public parks. These cannot both be true. If we are already well-connected to the trail network, then the public already has ready access to our amenities, yet this argument assumes that no one is currently using our field, pond, and playground. If the bridge would be so transformative that it attracts outsiders, then it must provide meaningful new connectivity, which undermines the claim that the Timberline route is sufficient.

Contradiction #2: The trail is unnecessary, but also dangerous. If the bridge would see so little use that it is not worth building, then it cannot simultaneously generate enough foot traffic to create a crime risk. High usage and concern of high crime are at least plausible together; low usage and high crime concern are not.

Contradiction #3: The project is too expensive, but also the Board blocked it because residents didn't want it. The opposition claims the project was previously blocked because "homeowners did not want to pay a special assessment." Alternatively, the flyer supporting construction states it was blocked by "a small group who spoke up at a regular meeting." If this was truly a broadly held opinion, why is an anonymous group now distributing flyers to promote their arguments? The fact that a group of residents felt the need to advance a competing viewpoint suggests the original blocking was not representative of broader community sentiment.

²¹ Great Outdoors Colorado, "Community Impact." Grants range from \$100,000 to \$2,000,000 per project and are described as "highly competitive." <https://goco.org/grants/programs/community-impact>

VII. What No One Else Is Talking About

Beyond the existing arguments, I want to raise several points that I believe deserve serious consideration but have not yet been part of this conversation.

The Illegal Crossing Is Gone: Our Access Has Gotten Worse

The flyer supporting construction notes that the widely used (but illegal) Power Trail access at Golden Willow and Globe Court has been permanently closed as a condition of the railroad's agreement to allow the Siphon Overpass. This is a crucial detail. Willow Springs residents who previously used that informal crossing to access the Power Trail have lost connectivity. The proposed bridge would not merely add a new amenity; it would restore and dramatically improve access that we have already lost. Voting against the bridge means accepting a permanent net reduction in our neighborhood's trail connectivity.

Fort Collins' Identity, and Ours

Fort Collins is one of only three Platinum-rated Bicycle Friendly Communities in the entire United States, as designated by the League of American Bicyclists.²² The City maintains over 280 miles of trails.²³ Colorado State University is one of eight Platinum Bicycle Friendly Universities in the U.S., and Fort Collins has more certified Bicycle Friendly Businesses (62) than any city in the country.²⁴

Cycling infrastructure and bicycle friendliness are central to our community identity. People move to Fort Collins in part because of this infrastructure and culture. The cycling and trail network is a core part of our city's brand, its economic development strategy, and its quality of life. Willow Springs choosing to wall itself off from the trail network is a statement of values that is out of step with the community we live in. It tells prospective buyers "This neighborhood opted out of the thing Fort Collins is best known for."

Aging in Place and Accessibility

The proposed bridge is ADA-compliant by design. As our neighborhood's demographics evolve, accessible, off-street connections to parks, schools, and the broader trail network, will become increasingly important for residents who can no longer drive or who rely on mobility devices. Trails are not just for cyclists and joggers. They are critical infrastructure for aging in place, for residents with disabilities, and for anyone who wants to move through their community without getting in a

²² League of American Bicyclists, "79 New and Renewing Bicycle Friendly Communities Recognized Nationwide" (January 2026). Fort Collins and Davis, CA renewed their Platinum status; only five communities have ever received this designation, with three currently holding it (Fort Collins, Davis, and Madison, WI).

<https://bikeleague.org/79-new-and-renewing-bicycle-friendly-communities-recognized-nationwide/>
²³ Visit Fort Collins, "Biking in Fort Collins." The city maintains more than 280 miles of bike lanes and trails.
<https://www.visitftcollins.com/things-to-do/outdoors/biking/>

²⁴ Bike Fort Collins, "Bicycle Friendly Business." Fort Collins is home to 62 certified Bicycle Friendly Businesses—the most of any city in the country. Colorado State University holds Platinum Bicycle Friendly University status.
<https://bikefortcollins.org/bicycle-friendly-business/>

car. Declining this bridge forecloses that option for our future selves and every future resident of Willow Springs.

Climate, Sustainability, and the Car Calculus

Every trip that moves from car to bicycle or foot is a trip that reduces emissions, reduces traffic, and reduces wear on our roads. Fort Collins has ambitious climate goals, and the City's investment in the Mail Creek Trail and Siphon Overpass reflects those priorities. The bridge would make car-free commuting and errand-running genuinely viable for many Willow Springs households. For families with school-age children, it could eliminate one or two car trips per day. Multiplied across the neighborhood, that is meaningful.

The “Eyes on the Trail” Effect

Urban planning research consistently shows that well-used public spaces are *safer*, not more dangerous. The principle is often called “natural surveillance” or “eyes on the street,” a concept developed by the urbanist Jane Jacobs in *The Death and Life of Great American Cities*.²⁵ A trail that is actively used by families, cyclists, dog walkers, and commuters is a trail that is constantly watched. It is the unused, disconnected, dead-end spaces that attract problems. Connecting Willow Springs to the Mail Creek Trail invites community, not crime. More people using the space means more witnesses, more accountability, and more investment in keeping it safe.

VIII. Conclusion

Ultimately this is a decision about what kind of neighborhood we want to live in, and I would like to offer a personal observation.

Last December, I was riding back from a long loop north of town on the Power Trail when I came over the new Siphon Overpass for the first time. As I took the Mail Creek Trail eastbound I could see Willow Springs, and the houses across the street from my own, right there. But, separated by a ditch, I had to ride past it, continue north along Timberline riding the sidewalk alongside traffic, and then loop back.

That extra few minutes is not a big deal for me, although Timberline wasn't exactly the most serene portion of my journey. But for my daughter, who is just gaining the confidence to ride beyond our cul-de-sac, it's the whole ride. For the family down the street with a child in a bike trailer, it's the difference between a trail adventure and staying home. For the retired couple on Willow Springs Way who walk for exercise, it's the difference between a flat, scenic, off-street loop versus a sidewalk next to semis.

²⁵ Jacobs, J., *The Death and Life of Great American Cities*. New York: Random House, 1961. Foundational work establishing the “eyes on the street” principle of natural surveillance; that well-used, actively observed public spaces are safer than isolated ones.

Fort Collins just spent \$4.7 million building a bridge over a railroad so that we could have a connected trail network. The City is now offering to spend additional funds to connect us to it. The research says our property values will increase. The data says crime will not follow. The infrastructure is already built and waiting for us. And the only thing standing between Willow Springs and a direct connection to one of the best trail systems in the United States is a vote.

I urge the Board to approve this project, and I urge my fellow residents to make their voices heard in support of it. The bridge is good policy, good economics, and good for our families. It would be a profound and lasting mistake to let this opportunity pass.

Respectfully submitted,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read 'R. Cramer', with a stylized, flowing script.

Ryan Cramer
1918 Pacific Court

Note: This letter may be shared publicly, in whole or in part, and posted alongside other community feedback. I welcome any questions or discussion about the data cited herein.